

UNIT-2

MANAGING HABITS

Neurology of Habits

The Neurology of Habits Habits are automatic behaviours that we no longer need to think about or make a choice about. We don't struggle with the decision to take a shower or brush our teeth; we just do it and we trust that we will always do these things, because they are habits.

CAUSES OF ADDICTION

In the past, addiction was viewed as stemming from an individual's moral failing and weakness of will (NIH, 2010). With the advances in scientific research, biological theories of addiction as a "brain disease" are now widely accepted; however, this point of view is still controversial. Many prefer to characterize it as a condition that requires continued management, rather than a disease, as it promotes the idea that addiction can be managed through behavioral changes and that the individual is ultimately in control of the condition.

The disease model is supported by the changes that occur in the brain as a result of continued substance use. Through a process of adaptation, the brain attempts to adapt to the presence of a substance in effort to function normally. The disease model asserts that while initial choice to use the substance may have been voluntary, over time behavioral choice is lessened as these neurobiological changes occur.

Not only do these changes modify one's initial response to a substance, they regulate:

The development of craving.

The distress associated with periods of abstinence (which is a key factor in relapse).

Whether or not we look at addiction as a "disease," we can clearly see that changes in the brain do occur that promote continued use -- both due to the rewarding feelings that the substance can initiate in the brain and also due to avoidance of withdrawal symptoms that present when dependence develops.

The Brain and Addiction

The most complex body organ, the brain, is impacted by substance use in 3 central areas:

- The brain stem. This controls basic bodily functions, including breathing, sleeping, and heart rate.
- The cerebral cortex. This controls executive functions, such as decision-making, planning, and sensory information processing.

- The limbic system. This is the body's emotional reward circuitry and controls our ability to experience pleasure and motivation for survival sustaining activities, which is activated by drugs of abuse

RELAXATION TECHNIQUES

Relaxation technique

1: Deep breathing

With its focus on full, cleansing breaths, deep breathing is a simple yet powerful relaxation technique. It's easy to learn, can be practiced almost anywhere, and provides a quick way to get your stress levels in check. Deep breathing is the cornerstone of many other relaxation practices, too, and can be combined with other relaxing elements such as aromatherapy and music. While apps and audio downloads can guide you through the process, all you really need is a few minutes and a place to sit quietly or stretch out.

How to practice deep breathing

- Sit comfortably with your back straight. Put one hand on your chest and the other on your stomach.
- Breathe in through your nose. The hand on your stomach should rise. The hand on your chest should move very little.
- Exhale through your mouth, pushing out as much air as you can while contracting your abdominal muscles. The hand on your stomach should move in as you exhale, but your other hand should move very little.
- Continue to breathe in through your nose and out through your mouth. Try to inhale enough so that your lower abdomen rises and falls. Count slowly as you exhale.
- If you find it difficult breathing from your abdomen while sitting up, try lying down. Put a small book on your stomach, and breathe so that the book rises as you inhale and falls as you exhale.

2: Progressive muscle relaxation

Progressive muscle relaxation is a two-step process in which you systematically tense and relax different muscle groups in the body. With regular practice, it gives you an intimate familiarity with what tension—as well as complete relaxation—feels like in different parts of your body. This can help you react to the first signs of the muscular tension that accompanies stress. And as your body relaxes, so will your mind.

Progressive muscle relaxation can be combined with deep breathing for additional stress relief.

Practicing progressive muscle relaxation

Consult with your doctor first if you have a history of muscle spasms, back problems, or other serious injuries that may be aggravated by tensing muscles.

Start at your feet and work your way up to your face, trying to only tense those muscles intended.

Loosen clothing, take off your shoes, and get comfortable.

Take a few minutes to breathe in and out in slow, deep breaths.

When you're ready, shift your attention to your right foot. Take a moment to focus on the way it feels.

Slowly tense the muscles in your right foot, squeezing as tightly as you can. Hold for a count of 10.

Relax your foot. Focus on the tension flowing away and how your foot feels as it becomes limp and loose.

Stay in this relaxed state for a moment, breathing deeply and slowly.

Shift your attention to your left foot. Follow the same sequence of muscle tension and release.

Move slowly up through your body, contracting and relaxing the different muscle groups.

It may take some practice at first, but try not to tense muscles other than those intended.

3: Body scan meditation

This is a type of meditation that focuses your attention on various parts of your body. Like progressive muscle relaxation, you start with your feet and work your way up. But instead of tensing and relaxing muscles, you simply focus on the way each part of your body feels, without labeling the sensations as either "good" or "bad".

Lie on your back, legs uncrossed, arms relaxed at your sides, eyes open or closed. Focus on your breathing for about two minutes until you start to feel relaxed.

Turn your focus to the toes of your right foot. Notice any sensations you feel while continuing to also focus on your breathing. Imagine each deep breath flowing to your toes. Remain focused on this area for three to five seconds (or more).

Move your focus to the sole of your right foot. Tune in to any sensations you feel in that part of your body and imagine each breath flowing from the sole of your foot. After one or two minutes, move your focus to your right ankle and repeat. Move to your calf, knee, thigh, hip, and then repeat the sequence for your left leg. From there, move up the torso, through the lower back and abdomen, the upper back and chest, and the shoulders. Pay close attention to any area of the body that causes you pain or discomfort.

After completing the body scan, relax for a while in silence and stillness, noting how your body feels. Then slowly open your eyes and stretch, if necessary.

4: Visualization

Visualization, or guided imagery, is a variation on traditional meditation that involves imagining a scene in which you feel at peace, free to let go of all tension and anxiety. Choose whatever setting is most calming to you, whether it's a tropical beach, a favorite childhood spot, or a quiet wooded glen.

You can practice visualization on your own or with an app or audio download to guide you through the imagery. You can also choose to do your visualization in silence or use listening aids, such as soothing music or a sound machine or a recording that matches your chosen setting: the sound of ocean waves if you've chosen a beach, for example.

Practicing visualization

Close your eyes and imagine your restful place. Picture it as vividly as you can: everything you see, hear, smell, taste, and feel. Just "looking" at it in your mind's eye like you would a photograph is not enough. Visualization works best if you incorporate as many sensory details as possible. For example, if you are thinking about a dock on a quiet lake:

See the sun setting over the water

Hear the birds singing

Smell the pine trees

Feel the cool water on your bare feet

Taste the fresh, clean air

Enjoy the feeling of your worries drifting away as you slowly explore your restful place. When you are ready, gently open your eyes and come back to the present. Don't worry if you sometimes zone out or lose track of where you are during a visualization session. This is normal. You may also experience feelings of heaviness in your limbs, muscle twitches, or yawning. Again, these are normal responses.

5: Self-massage

You're probably already aware how much a professional massage at a spa or health club can help reduce stress, relieve pain, and ease muscle tension. What you may not be aware of is that you can experience some of the same benefits at home or work by practicing self-massage, or trading massages with a loved one.

Try taking a few minutes to massage yourself at your desk between tasks, on the couch at the end of a hectic day, or in bed to help you unwind before sleep. To enhance relaxation, you can use aromatic oil, scented lotion, or combine self-massage with mindfulness or deep breathing techniques.

6: Mindfulness meditation

Mindfulness has become extremely popular in recent years, garnering headlines and endorsements from celebrities, business leaders, and psychologists alike. So, what is mindfulness? Rather than worrying about the future or dwelling on the past, mindfulness switches your focus to what's happening right now, enabling you to be fully engaged in the present moment.

Meditations that cultivate mindfulness have long been used to reduce stress, anxiety, depression, and other negative emotions. Some of these practices bring you into the present by focusing your attention on a single repetitive action, such as your breathing or a few repeated words. Other forms of mindfulness meditation encourage you to follow and then release internal thoughts or sensations. Mindfulness can also be applied to activities such as walking, exercising, or eating.

Using mindfulness to stay focused on the present might seem straightforward, but it takes practice to reap all the benefits. When you first start practicing, you'll likely find that your focus keeps wandering back to your worries or regrets. But don't get disheartened. Each time you draw your focus back to the present, you're strengthening a new mental habit that can help you break free of fretting about the past or stressing about the future. Using an app or audio download can also help focus your attention, especially when you're starting out.

7: Rhythmic movement and mindful exercise

The idea of exercising may not sound particularly soothing, but rhythmic exercise that gets you into a flow of repetitive movement can produce the relaxation response. Examples include:

- Running
- Walking
- Swimming
- Dancing
- Rowing
- Climbing